

POWER CAMPAIGN (From left) Congress leaders Sonia Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi and Mallikarjun Kharge

ANI

COVER STORY

KARNATAKA

READYING FOR FUTURE BATTLES

THE CONGRESS HOPES TO DO A KARNATAKA IN RAJASTHAN, MADHYA PRADESH AND CHHATTISGARH, STATES THAT ARE SCHEDULED TO GO TO THE POLLS LATER THIS YEAR. CAN THE PARTY REPEAT ITS MAGIC?

By **KAUSHIK DEKA** *with* **ROHIT PARIHAR** *and* **RAHUL NORONHA**

Asked whether he would rebel if the high command doesn't make him the chief minister of Karnataka, Congress leader D.K. Shivakumar, on his way to Delhi on May 16, said that his primary concern was winning at least 20 of the 28 Lok Sabha seats from the state next year. The response could have been an attempt to evade giving a direct answer on the chief ministerial battle, but he rightly picked up the next big challenge, not just for his own party brass but also for rival BJP. The Grand Old Party expects to carry this momentum to 2024 when the Lok Sabha polls will be held, while the saffron party will hope to turn it around, again in its favour.

With 135 seats in the 224-seat assembly, the